Expedition hopes to find aviator Amelia Earhart's plane on remote island

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Purdue University: The research team departed Kiribati's capital on Wednesday and hope to arrive at the suspected wreck site by Monday

A team of researchers are on their way to a remote island to inspect what they think could be the wreckage of famed aviator Amelia Earhart's plane.

The group, from the US-based Archaeological Legacy Institute (ALI) and Purdue University, are expected to arrive at Nikumaroro Island in the Pacific Ocean by Monday in the hopes of solving the mystery of her disappearance.

The American pioneer vanished while attempting to circumnavigate the globe in 1937, spawning decades of speculation on her fate.

The team are aiming to find what has been called the Taraia Object, first spotted sitting on the edge of a lagoon off Nikumaroro in satellite imagery in 2020.

Purdue University said the object had since been confirmed to have been visible in aerial photography of the area dating back to 1938.

The researchers are currently roughly halfway through their journey to the remote atoll aboard the Marin Mainiku, a Kiribati National Shipping Line vessel.

They departed the capital of Kiribati on Wednesday to begin the 830-mile journey to Nikumaroro, which is also part of the multi-island country.

When they eventually arrive, they will have to navigate through a narrow gap created in the atoll's reef by the British in 1963 - the last time the island was inhabited.

"Finding Amelia Earhart's Electra aircraft would be the discovery of a lifetime," Richard Pettigrew, head of the ALI and the expedition lead, said.

Earhart had already successfully flown from California across South America, Africa and Asia in her Electra twin-engine plane when she arrived in Lae, Papua New Guinea on 2 July 1937.

From there, she and her navigator Fred Noonan had planned to travel towards Hawaii and then finally back to California.

But her plane vanished without a trace while trying to reach Howland Island, a remote, uninhabited coral island near Nikumaroro, to refuel.

Earhart's disappearance spawned numerous theories - from a simple crash due to fuel exhaustion to more elaborate claims of interference.

The official explanation is that the plane suffered communication problems while the two struggled to find the island, and Earhart eventually crashed into the ocean when she ran out of fuel.

While this version of events is largely accepted, no physical evidence has ever been recovered.



Getty Images: Amelia Earhart disappeared over the Pacific Ocean while piloting her Electra plane in 1937

One theory is that Earhart unintentionally navigated to Nikumaroro, where she ditched her plane and died a castaway.

Images of the so-called Taraia Object show what could be the remnants of a small aircraft sitting in shallow waters.

But some - including rival explorers - have expressed scepticism that this could be a plane, let alone Earhart's.

Ric Gillespie, who specialises in recovering historic aircraft wrecks, told news agency Reuters that the object looked like a tree that had fallen from the atoll into the nearby water.

"I'd love to find that airplane. It ain't gonna happen," he said.

The researchers en route to the island credit Gillespie with previously finding evidence of a human presence on the atoll in the 1930s and forensic analysis of skeletal remains found there in the 1940s they say lend credence to their theory.

But Gillespie suspects Earhart's plane had likely broken apart and its fragments carried into the depths of the Pacific long ago.

Previous attempts to find her Electra have also come up short.

In 2024, a group of researchers said they may have found it lying around 4,877m (16,000ft) below the surface near Howland Island through sonar imaging - but this was later confirmed to be a rock formation.

Similarly, an expedition in 2019, conducted by the marine archaeologist who discovered the Titanic wreck, to investigate a photograph of what might have been a landing gear protruding from the water near Nikumaroro also failed to find anything.

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
wreckage	n.	（飞机、船只等的）残骸	“the wreckage of famed aviator Amelia Earhart’s plane” 埃尔哈特座机的残骸；不可数名词，空难与事故新闻高频
aviator	n.	飞行员、飞行家（早期用语）	“famed aviator Amelia Earhart” 著名飞行家埃尔哈特；现代新闻多作 pilot，aviator 自带年代感
circumnavigate	v.	环绕（地球）航行	“attempting to circumnavigate the globe in 1937” 1937 年试图环球飞行；circum-（环绕）+ navigate（航行），环球航行新闻常用
spawned	v.	引发、催生（大量事物）	“spawning decades of speculation on her fate” 引发数十年的猜测；本义“产卵”，引申义常接 speculation/theories/rumours，新闻高频
speculation	n.	猜测、揣测	“decades of speculation on her fate” 对她下落长达数十年的猜测；另义“投机买卖”，财经新闻常见
atoll	n.	环礁	“the remote atoll” 偏远的环礁；同篇还有 reef（礁）、lagoon（潟湖），太平洋地理词群
lagoon	n.	潟湖、泻湖	“on the edge of a lagoon off Nikumaroro” 位于尼库马罗岛外的潟湖边缘
navigated	v.	航行、导航（到某地）	“unintentionally navigated to Nikumaroro” 无意中航至尼库马罗岛；第二义项“（在复杂

词	词性	中文	备注
			局面中）找到出路”，如 navigate the crisis
remnants	n.	残余物、残迹	“the remnants of a small aircraft” 小型飞机的残迹；常用复数，也指残存的影响或痕迹
scepticism	n.	怀疑、质疑	“have expressed scepticism that this could be a plane” 对那是否是一架飞机表示怀疑；英式拼写，美式作 skepticism
let alone	phr.	更不用说、遑论	“that this could be a plane, let alone Earhart’s” 连那是不是飞机都存疑，更不用说是不是埃尔哈特的了；雅思阅读高频结构
forensic	adj.	法医的、法证鉴定的	“forensic analysis of skeletal remains” 对骸骨的法证分析；第二义项“细致取证式的”，如 a forensic examination of the accounts
lend credence to	phr.	为……提供佐证、增强可信度	“lend credence to their theory” 为他们的理论提供佐证；credence 名词“可信度”，反面用法 give little credence to
come up short	phr.	未达目标、落空	“Previous attempts to find her Electra have also come up short” 此前寻找座机的努力也都无果；本义“（长度）不够”
ditched	v.	（飞机）水上迫降	“she ditched her plane and died a castaway” 她让飞机迫降水面，最终死在荒岛上；本义“抛弃”，航空义为第二义项
castaway	n.	荒岛漂流者、落难者	“died a castaway” 以漂流者身份死去；源自 cast away（被抛弃），《鲁滨逊漂流记》式叙事常用

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fragments	n.	碎片、碎块	“its fragments carried into the depths of the Pacific” 飞机碎片被带入太平洋深处；也指“零散片段”
refuel	v.	（给飞机等）加油、补给燃料	“trying to reach Howland Island … to refuel” 试图抵达豪兰岛加油；引申用法 refuel the debate（给争论再添燃料）
protruding	v.	突出、伸出	“a landing gear protruding from the water” 露出水面的一只起落架；固定搭配 protrude from
expedition	n.	考察队、探险（活动）	“an expedition in 2019” 2019 年的一次考察；新闻中也指大型远征、科考